

I believe many people talk about artificial intelligence as if it's just a neutral tool that can be used for good or bad, but I think that view misses some of the most important ethical problems. AI is never really separate from human values or intentions. Most of the time, it reflects the priorities of whoever designs or controls it. Because of this, I don't think it makes sense to treat AI as the main moral agent. The real responsibility always comes back to humans, especially those with the most power over how AI is built and who gets to use it. If only big companies or governments are in charge, AI could easily make existing inequalities even worse. However, if we developed AI in a way that allows it to learn alongside people, it can remain open to a variety of moral perspectives and be governed transparently. I truly believe that could actually help improve human well-being. I think ethical debates about AI should be focused less on treating AI as an independent threat and more on the human issues of power, accountability, and making sure that there is fair access. AI itself isn't really ethical or unethical, but its moral consequences depend on who controls it. So, I think ethical responsibility should be about preventing the concentration of power and social inequality, not about seeing AI itself as the main threat.

AI is often spoken about as if it makes decisions the way humans do, but that idea doesn't hold up when we actually look at how AI really works. As discussed in *Artificial Intelligence: A Guide for Thinking Humans*(2019), AI doesn't really understand the meaning, values, or morality in the way people do. They do not have the ability to reason ethically or to form better intentions. They recognize patterns based on data and follow objectives defined by humans. Which means that when AI produces an outcome that affects people, it is tied to a human's choice about training data, system design, and what the AI is optimized to do. Treating AI as if it were a moral decision-maker can be misleading, because it shifts attention away from the people

and institutions responsible for building and deploying the system. For this reason, ethical responsibility cannot be placed on AI itself, but must remain with humans who decide how AI is created and used.

Even when AI isn't intentionally harmful, it can still cause serious ethical problems when it makes decisions. In *Weapons of Math Destruction*(2016), Cathy O'Neil explains how algorithmic systems often present themselves as objective and neutral, even though they're built based on human assumptions and priorities. These systems can reinforce inequality when used in areas such as hiring, education, or financial decision-making, even when AI is very hard to understand and even harder to argue with. One of the key dangers highlighted is that algorithms can distance decision-makers from responsibility. Some of those harmful outcomes are blamed on the system rather than the people who designed or approved it. When algorithms are operating on a large scale, small biases and flawed assumptions can have widespread consequences, which can make inequality easier to reproduce and harder to see. This shows how AI can amplify existing power structures instead of correcting them.

The ethical problems with AI become even more obvious when you look at how automated systems are used by institutions that affect people's lives. In *Automating Inequality: How High-Tech Tools Profile, Police, and Punish the Poor*(2018), Virginia Eubanks shows that these systems are often used in public services and end up hurting poor and marginalized communities the most. Even though AI is supposed to make things more efficient or fair. Usually, AI can lead to more surveillance, less access to resources, and even fewer opportunities for people who already feel very vulnerable. Automation doesn't actually remove human judgment; it just hides the policy decisions inside technology and can make them harder to question. When people are harmed by automated decisions, they usually don't get much

explanation or a way to challenge them, which shifts even more power away from individuals and toward big institutions. To me, this shows that ethical issues in AI are really about who has power and how technology is used to control or limit people.

All of these sources help to really strengthen my main argument. Mitchell's work shows that AI isn't a moral agent and doesn't have human understanding or ethical intent. O'Neil builds on the idea that by showing how algorithmic systems can still cause a lot of harm when they're treated as objective and allowed to run without transparency or accountability. Eubanks adds an important human perspective by showing how automated systems used by institutions often hurt people with the least power. When you put all of this together, it becomes very clear that the real ethical concerns about AI are not just about being afraid of the technology itself, but instead it all points to the same idea: AI reflects human priorities, and when it's used in powerful systems, it can make inequality worse and let decision-makers avoid responsibility. That's why I believe debates about ethical AI should focus on human control, governance, and fair access, not on treating AI as if it's an independent moral threat.

At the same time, I can see how these same sources might challenge parts of my own view, especially my belief that AI should be able to learn with humans instead of being tightly restricted. Mitchell points out that the limits of AI understanding, and also warns against overestimating what AI can do, which could support a more cautious or limited approach to AI development. O'Neil's work shows how algorithms can cause real harm when used at scale, suggesting that stricter rules or limits might be needed to prevent abuse. Eubanks also shows how automated systems can make inequality worse and reduce human agency, which could be a reason to restrict AI use in sensitive areas. From this angle, it's possible to argue that the ethical

risks of AI are so serious that letting these systems expand or adapt freely would be irresponsible, especially when powerful institutions are in control.

While considering these concerns, I do see the real ethical problem a little bit differently. I agree with Mitchell that AI lacks moral understanding and should not be treated as a moral agent. I also agree with O'Neil and Eubanks that algorithmic systems can amplify inequality, hide accountability, and cause real harm when used in large institutions. I do not think that AI learning is the main danger, but I truly believe the real problem lies in who controls that learning and whose values shape it. If we have overly restrictive rules, especially from the same powerful groups that already control AI, then ethics just becomes another way to keep power. I don't think ethical AI needs to be developed with caution, but it also needs shared governance, transparency, and genuine inclusion of multiple outlooks. If we do not address human power directly, even the best moral guidelines can end up protecting those in charge rather than promoting justice.

I think that artificial intelligence is more than just a neutral tool, but it's also not a moral being that should be blamed for ethical problems. AI doesn't have human understanding or moral intent, so responsibility must stay with the people who design and use it. Algorithmic systems can make inequality worse and hide accountability, especially when they're treated as objective and left unchallenged. This harm is even worse when large institutions use automation in ways that harm marginalized communities. All of this makes it clear to me that the real ethical issue in AI isn't about intelligence itself, but about the humans that control it. Ethical AI depends on how people choose to govern technology, share its benefits, and take responsibility for what happens. In the end, the future of AI ethics will be shaped by whether humans are willing to face up to inequality, accountability, and control in the systems they create.

References

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